

Project Milestone 5: User Evaluation

1) 3 User Scenarios

Primary User Task 1: Plan today from scattered inputs

- Milestone 2: Start a briefing and gather tasks from Gmail/Calendar. Goal: go from “something's due somewhere at some time” to a locked top 3 for today, each with a first step.
- Scenario read to participant: *“You’ve just woken up and realize you have a full day of classes/work, an assignment due, a midterm coming up, or a pile of unread emails. You want to walk into the day with a clear head instead of scrolling through everything that’s pending. Show me how you’d use this app to figure out what actually matters today and lock in your plan.”*
- Success criteria: participant starts morning briefing, is able to see upcoming tasks or adds tasks manually, selects 3 Anchors for the day; process is intuitive and does not take up too much time.

Primary User Task 2: Start the next action

- Milestone 2: Find and begin the single smallest next step for the priority task, without having to decide what to do.
- Scenario read to participant: *“You’ve made a plan for your day and identified these three main Anchors. However, you’re having trouble getting started as it feels like there’s so much to do for these Anchors. Using this app, show me how you would break down the task and actually sit down and begin working on your first Anchor in a Focus Session.”*
- Success criteria: participant starts the opener/first step for their top Anchor (e.g., begins a focus session) and knows the first step to begin without pausing to decide what to do.

Primary User Task 3: Close out the day and roll over

- Milestone 2: Mark what got done, carry unfinished work forward. Success: reflection saved, unfinished tasks appear in tomorrow's plan.
- Scenario read to participant: *“It’s the end of the day. You got through some of what you planned, but not all of it. Show me how you’d use this app to wrap up and see what you got done as well as decide what happens to what’s left.”*
- Success criteria: participant saves a reflection, and any unfinished Anchor is confirmed to roll into tomorrow’s plan.

2) Evaluation Interview Protocol

Total session length: 30–45 minutes. Sessions will be screen-recorded (with audio) with the participant's consent, and one team member should take live notes while another facilitates.

Recording: use the phone's built-in screen recorder with microphone enabled

- iPhone: Settings → Control Center → add Screen Recording if not already added. Swipe into Control Center, long-press the record icon (not a single tap), enable the microphone option, then Start.
- Android: swipe down twice for Quick Settings → Screen Recorder. Enable microphone audio before starting
- Maybe a second phone or laptop webcam angled at the participant's face captures non-verbal cues (frowns, hesitation) for the qualitative notes?

Introduction and Consent (3 minutes)

“Hi, thanks for taking the time to test this with us today! We're students building an app called Anchor, meant to help people cut through decision fatigue by narrowing each day down to just three focus tasks.”

“We're going to give you a phone with the app open, and walk you through a few everyday situations. This session should take about 30 to 45 minutes total. As you go, please think aloud as much as possible. Feel free to say whatever's going through your head. There's no need to explain or narrate perfectly, just talk the way you'd think to yourself.”

“This is a test of the app, not of you. If anything is confusing or doesn't work the way you expect, that's exactly what we want to find out, and it's on us, not you. We'll be screen recording with audio so we can review it afterward, and everything stays private within our team. Is that okay with you?”

[\[Get verbal and signed consent to record.\]](#)

Think Aloud Session (15-20 minutes)

[Facilitator notes:](#)

- [Read each of the three scenarios below, one at a time, in order.](#)
- [Do not help or hint unless the participant is completely stuck for 30+ seconds. Note this as a failure/assist point if it happens.](#)

“So I'm going to read out a few scenarios and then just talk through what you're thinking and doing as you try to complete the tasks.

Task 1: Plan today from scattered inputs

Scenario read to participant: “You’ve just woken up and realize you have a full day of classes, an assignment due, a midterm coming up, and a pile of unread emails. You want to walk into the day with a clear head instead of scrolling through everything that’s pending. Show me how you’d use this app to figure out what actually matters today and lock in your plan.”

Success criteria: participant starts morning briefing, is able to see upcoming tasks or adds tasks manually, selects 3 Anchors for the day; process is intuitive and does not take up too much time

Task 2: Start the next action

Scenario read to participant:

“You’ve made a plan for your day and identified these three main Anchors. However, you’re having trouble getting started as it feels like there’s so much to do for these Anchors. Using this app, show me how you would break down the task and actually sit down and begin working on your first Anchor in a Focus Session.”

Success criteria: participant starts the opener/first step for their top Anchor (e.g., begins a focus session) and knows the first step to begin without pausing to decide what to do.

Task 3: Close out the day and roll over

Scenario read to participant:

“It’s the end of the day. You got through some of what you planned, but not all of it. Show me how you’d use this app to wrap up and see what you got done as well as decide what happens to what’s left.”

Success criteria: participant saves a reflection, and any unfinished Anchor is confirmed to roll into tomorrow’s plan.

Quantitative Usability Survey (5 minutes)

“Before we chat about how that felt, I’m going to hand you a quick survey. It’s about 9 questions, just tap the number that matches how much you agree with each statement. There’s no right answer, and feel free to be honest, even if it’s critical. Take your time”

Debrief Interview (5 minutes)

“Thanks for filling that out. Now I just want to chat for a few minutes about your overall experience”

Open-ended questions, asked conversationally:

- Overall, how did that feel compared to how you currently keep track of your day?
- Was there any moment where you weren’t sure what to do next? Walk me through what you were thinking there.

- What's one thing you'd want changed before you'd actually use this daily?
- Was there anything that surprised you in a good or bad way?
- (If relevant) I noticed you paused on [X] what was going through your mind there?

“That's everything! Thank you so much for your time and honesty today, this is genuinely going to help us improve the app. Do you have any questions for us before we wrap up?”

3) Quantitative Success Metrics

Metrics Table:

Metric	Target	Result
Task completion	≥80% of participants complete each task independently	
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	
Taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5 Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 2	
Assists needed	No facilitator assistance for at least 4 of 6 participants per task	
Errors / wrong turns	≤1 error per task on average	

1. Madison_Nami_1 - Recent UC Berkeley Education of Science graduate with Anxiety

Metric	Goal for per participant	Result
Task success on first attempt	Complete the tasks	Task 1: yes Task 2: no Task 3: yes
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	Task 1: 1:13 Task 2: 1:26 Task 3: 0:19
Number of taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5	Task 1: 12 Task 2: 14 Task 3: 2

	Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation. Targeted: Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 2	Task 1: 3 Task 2: 2 Task 3: 2
Number of assists needed/buttons that they don't understand	No assist at all and no misunderstanding of any buttons	Task 1: 1 Task 2: 3 Task 3: 0
Number of errors / wrong turns	No errors/ wrong turns	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 3 Task 3: 0

2. Madison_Nami_2 - UC Berkeley Master of Design, stressed due to senior thesis

Metric	Goal for per participant	Result
Task success on first attempt	Complete the tasks	Task 1: yes Task 2: no Task 3: no
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	Task 1: 0: 28 Task 2: 2: 20 Task 3: 0: 03
Number of taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5 Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	Task 1: 7 Task 2: 5 Task 3: 1
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 2	Task 1: 2 Task 2: 2 Task 3: 2
Number of assists needed/buttons that they don't understand	No assist at all and no misunderstanding of any buttons	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 1 Task 3: 0
Number of errors / wrong turns	No errors/ wrong turns	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 3 Task 3: 1

3. Thanhbinh - Recent UC Berkeley Graduate in CS

Metric	Goal for per participant	Result
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Task success on first attempt	Complete the tasks	Task 1: yes Task 2: no (had to instruct) Task 3: yes (had to reprompt)
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	Task 1: 0:27 Task 2: 2:10 Task 3: ~5 mins (had to instruct)
Number of taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5 Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	Task 1: 7 Task 2: 30 Task 3: 35
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 2	Task 1: 1 Task 2: 1 Task 3: 3
Number of assists needed/buttons that they don't understand	No assist at all and no misunderstanding of any buttons	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 2 Task 3: 2
Errors / wrong turns	No errors/ wrong turns	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 3 Task 3: 3

4. Sampurn - Recent Berkeley Grad with Anxiety, New Grad SWE

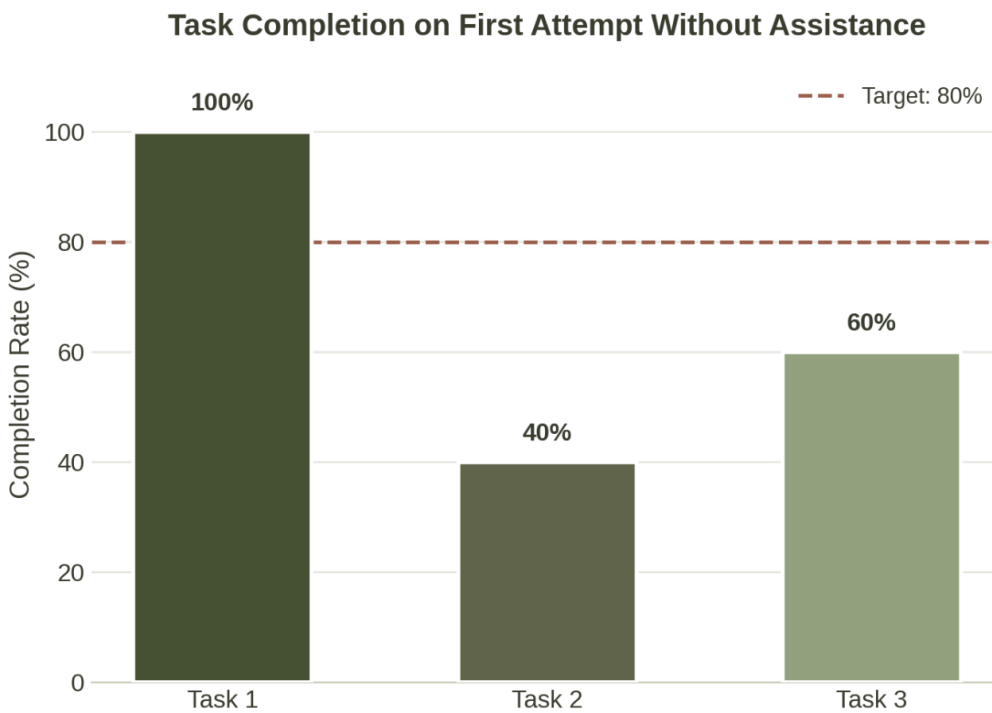
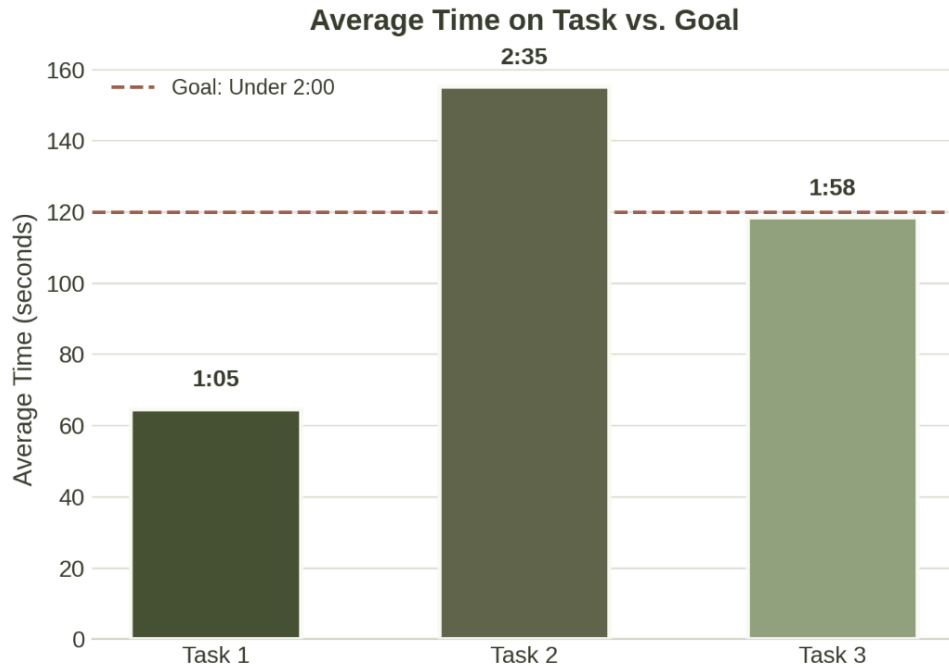
Metric	Goal for per participant	Result
Task success on first attempt	Complete the tasks	Task 1: yes Task 2: yes Task 3: yes
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	Task 1: 1min Task 2: 2 min Task 3: 1.5 min
Number of taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5 Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	Task 1: 4 Task 2: 6 Task 3: 5
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 2	Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 3: 3

Number of assists needed/buttons that they don't understand	No assist at all and no misunderstanding of any buttons	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 3 Task 3: 4
Errors / wrong turns	No errors/ wrong turns	Task 1: 0 Task 2: 0 Task 3: 0

5. Reed - Recent Berkeley graduate in Economics

Metric	Goal for per participant	Result
Task success on first attempt	Complete the tasks	Task 1: yes Task 2: no, had to intervene for instruction Task 3: yes
Time on task	Under 2 minutes	Task 1: 2:15 Task 2: 5:00 Task 3: 3:00
Number of taps/clicks to completion	Minimize unnecessary steps. Targeted: Task 1: 5 Task 2: 10 Task 2: 5	Task 1: 5 Task 2: 12 Task 3: 4
Number of screens per task	Minimize unnecessary navigation Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 2: 3	Task 1: 2 Task 2: 1 Task 3: 2
Number of assists needed/buttons that they don't understand	No assist at all and no misunderstanding of any buttons	Task 1: 4 Task 2: 1 Task 3: 0
Errors / wrong turns	No errors/ wrong turns	Task 1: 6 Task 2: 10 Task 3: 3

2 Figures:

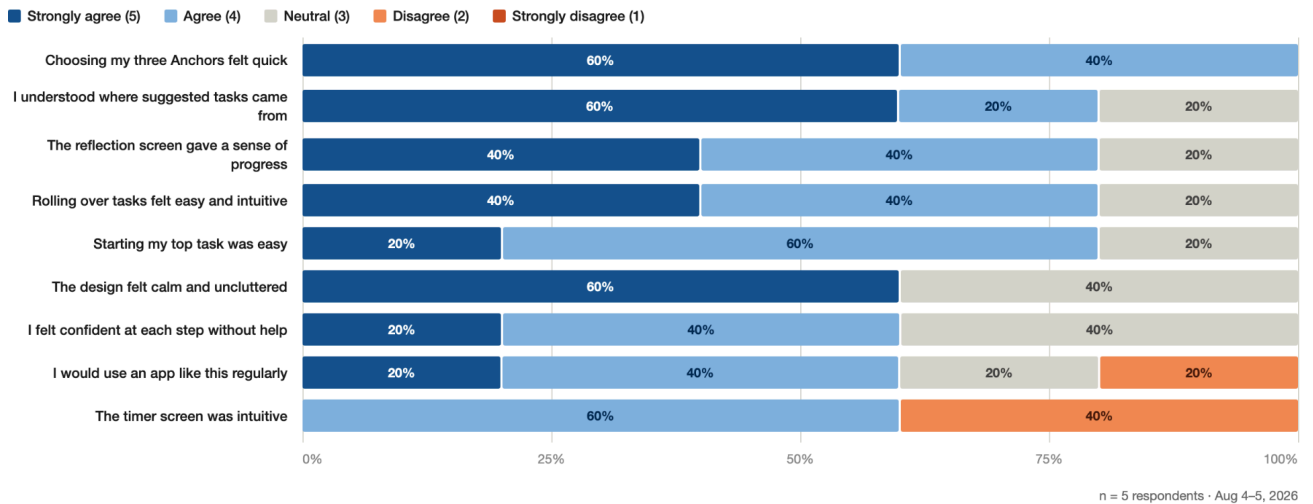


Usability Survey

<https://forms.gle/LExQxcNtxUvTV4L76>

Usability survey results

Anchor App - replies to nine statements on a 1–5 agreement scale



4) Qualitative Metrics

Observation Logs:

Participant 1 (UC Berkeley Master of Design):

Quotes:

1. “If I click this, would it be accomplished or?”
2. “Will it ring when it’s over?”
3. “Maybe it’s telling you how long the task is?”
4. “It might feel like an extra step because I use Google Calendar or personal alarms, so it’s nice to have the actual physical sound like vibration...for this one, you have to check your phone to see when time is up”
5. “When adding your task, adding a specific time so they’re like in order would be better”
6. “Alarm setting or something when you’re tasked, I think adding a time factor like 10 minutes pretty much to be your reminder part”
7. “Maybe there should be a screen save feature”
8. “Is the time like a reminder for you in 25 minutes you should start this task or is it this task will be 25 minutes long, and you’re setting the timer?”

Insights:

1. Icon confusion (task check circles, focus timer)
2. Would be annoying checking, so add alarm/vibration

3. Time order on tasks request
4. Notification before tasks due request

Participant 2 (UC Berkeley Master of Design):

Task Hesitation Triggers:

1. Paused for 3 seconds when attempting Task 2. Unsure a focus session means and how to start one
2. Paused for 2 seconds after clicking “tomorrow” button. Seemed unsure of the button’s purpose and the resulting actions
3. Hesitated before clicking “I started” and seemed unsure what it was supposed to prompt

Non-verbal cue:

1. Smiled after seeing the growth garden

Quotes:

1. “Focus session...? Is that part of this?”
2. “I’m wondering if it would tell me the following tasks after the first step... because like thesis research is like a really broad thing.”
3. “Anchor as an app would be really helpful for approaching this cuz it’s like oh I have to do my thesis which is really overwhelming. How can I break this down into smaller tasks?”
4. “wondering if there’s a way to kind of further itemize it or if I could add details maybe from other sources like my drive or like Claude as like a repository to kind of draw information.”
5. "Oh, I guess it just shifts it... Out of sight, out of mind."
6. “I like that there’s a visual to like kind of I guess like visualize your progress and it kind of gives like a metaphor for like this and then maybe you’ll get it to see more beautiful as you work through it.”

Insights:

1. Expected the the tool to decompose broad tasks beyond just a single "first step" displayed
2. Said they wanted to pull context from outside tools/sources rather than manually re-entering info

Participant 3 (Recent UC Berkeley Graduate in CS)

Quotes:

1. “I guess this a homepage for future oriented stuff”
2. “Part of me want to write more like description, but I do like the first step suggestion”
3. “When i’m editing this (tasks), part of me want to see the calender...cuz it’s easier to add”
4. “If there’s a plus button here (next to the tomorrow on this week page)”, i would want to add that”
5. “If I want to add midterm for Wednesday(tomorrow), I can’t add it here (tomorrow section), I have to go through this (today’s anchor adding field)...O ok now I see (can select the date while adding tasks in this week page)....It took me around 2 minutes to figure out this, but now I feel good about it”

6. “It felt like off the bat, kinda todo notes app, not apparent until i dig more deep than that more like reflection and breaking things down”
7. “I prefer to brain down everything myself, and this app give me the first step”

Task Hesitation Triggers:

1. Unclear task-starting flow - feeling lost while starting the tasks
2. Need for controlling breaking the task down - user wants to take control of task breaking down process.
3. Value of first step-suggestion - users appreciate the starting support
4. Need for Calendar Context - user wants to select tasks from calendar
5. Missing contextual add control while adding tasks from this week screen - user wants to add tasks more easily
6. Hidden date selection while adding tasks - users want to see clearer guidance while adding tasks from different dates
7. Unclear product value

Insights:

1. The app’s workflow is not immediately apparent causing users to take a while to figure out the app’s purpose
2. Hidden and disconnected task-entry causing task-switching cost
3. Users value first-step suggestion, but still want control over the task breakdowns

Participant 4 (New Grad SWE with Anxiety):

Task hesitation triggers:

1. Stalled on the “choose an anchor” step, did not know what the word meant in this context and suggested “choose a task” instead.
2. Paused at “Start 5 min,” unclear whether it started the task itself or only a timer
3. Reached the end of a focus session early and found no way to finish it, then no way to leave the timer screen at all
4. Did not navigate to Reflection unprompted, would not have thought to look for it on their own
5. Tried to reverse the “I started” state and stopped when nothing responded
6. When cleared tasks, she was unsure whether the action had taken effect

Quotes:

1. “Compared to other things I use, it’s better, it’s prettier. I just use a calendar and reminders app.”
2. “The reflection part was not clear that it is a pipeline to close the day at the end of the day.”
3. “I just do what this app does in my head, so this would help reduce mental load.”
4. “Would it show the next step when I am done?”
5. “Garden looks nice”
6. “It’s a lot more intuitive trying it the second time”

Non Verbal Cues:

1. She tapped “I started” a few times in a row when nothing happened, then stopped and just looked at the screen.
2. She smiled when the Garden loaded with the fish and stayed on it, scrolling around and clicking for a bit before moving on.
3. On the second run she looked visibly more relaxed, moving through the flow without stopping.
4. She periodically zoomed in in some places.

Think-Aloud Insights:

1. Reflection reads as a separate feature, not the end of the day’s flow
2. Getting started takes extra steps
3. Garden looks nice
4. Liked the swipe to add and delete
5. Timer overlay blocks the bottom of the screen
6. Some text was too small for her
7. It was a lot easier for her to navigate through all the steps in the second try.

Participant 5 (Recent Berkeley graduate in Economics):

Hesitation triggers:

1. Did not start with the Morning Briefing for Task 1, explored freely, then went to This Week to add tasks manually.
2. Paused at “Start 5 min,” unsure if it started the task or only a timer.
3. Paused at “Start weekly briefing,” unsure what it did.
4. Went looking for a sound/alarm setting and could not confirm one existed.

Quotes:

1. “What’s the today’s anchors section?”
2. “What does start in five minutes mean? It takes five minutes to do?”
3. “The garden section, I didn’t know what it was until I looked at it more. I think generally just getting used to how everything works together, it’s organized, it just takes a bit of getting used to”
4. “For the day section here, maybe having Friday or Saturday still listed, because on the main slide it’s listed by Friday, Saturday, Sunday. So having both the date but also the day of the week could be useful, just like referencing.”
5. “I like the reflection section and also it includes health stuff like steps of the day which a lot of people are trying to keep up with. And also just reflection of what got in the way, it helps you focus on, okay, I identify the problem, but now I have to solve that going forward”

Insights:

1. Terminology ambiguity, “Anchor” is not self-explanatory, the participant had to ask what Today’s Anchors meant and did not recognize “Start weekly briefing” as an action
2. Timer duration ambiguity, it’s unclear whether “Start 5 min” means the task takes five minutes, or is a five minute focus block, also unclear whether duration is adjustable or has an audible end.
3. Wants time-block visualization, the participant plans by blocking hours in a calendar and wants duration shown spatially, not only as a countdown.
4. Feature discoverability, Garden’s purpose only became clear after exploration, overall the app “takes getting used to”
5. Positive (reflection and health tracking) reflection framing (identify what got in the way, then solve it) and step/sleep logging were the standout liked features
6. Requested that the This Week day strip show both weekday name and date together for easier referencing.

Thematic Coding

Code	What it captures	Participants
A. Invented terminology/vocabulary	Product-specific words like choose an “Anchor” do not map to a recognizable action that it represented	P4, P5, P2
B. Duration as label was not intuitive	“Start 5 min” reads as task length, instead of a start a short timer button	P4, P5, P1
C. Ambiguous check affordance	Unclear what tapping a circle or icon commits to	P1, P4
D. Trapped in the timer	No early finish/exit, and the timer overlay sometimes blocks the bottom part of the screen	P4
E. Irreversible state	“I started” could not be undone or edited	P4

F. Silent action, and no end-of-session signal	Clearing tasks did not give clear confirmation it happened. No sound, vibration, or alert when the timer is up.	P1, P4, P5
G. Hidden closing step	Reflection is not easily found and understood as the day's closing screen	P4, P3
H. Depth only found on second look	Core app value surfaces only after second exploration	P4, P3, P5, P2
I. Missing time structure	Wants due times, ordering, reminders, day plus date	P1, P5, P4
J. Visual design including the "Garden" screen was well-liked	Aesthetics and the garden metaphor are praised and stood out as the unique feature, and said to help motivate	P4, P2, P5
K. Reflection framing valued	Naming what got in the way, plus health logging was liked	P5, P4
L. Reduces mental load, Structure appreciated	Externalizing what users currently hold in their head was helpful to reduce overwhelm. Organization and breaking things down make sense once seen, on a second attempt.	P3, P4, P5
M. First-step suggestion was liked, but users want control over the breakdown, or show future steps	The single suggested first step is appreciated as a starting push, but users want to go further themselves and add their own detail	P2, P3, P4

Grouping

Group	Codes	Pattern
1. Not knowing what an action will do	A, B, C	Users could not always tell what an action would produce before pressing it
2. Not knowing what happened and getting back out	D, E, F, I	After acting on some buttons, users got no clear confirmation (with completing tasks), no time cues (when timer ended), and no way to reverse or exit (out of the timer).
3. Reaching the valued features	G, H, J, K, L, N	The features users valued or liked the most (like the Garden, and Reflection screen) were the ones they found last

Groups A, B, C cluster on labels that do not communicate their action properly. D, E, F, I cluster on the system not responding as wanted, or not letting users back out. G, H, J, K, L, M cluster on the app's unique payoff not being clear at the start.

Three Usability Themes

Theme 1: Anchor's labels describe the app's own concepts rather than the action they perform, so users cannot predict what a certain button will do.

Codes: *A (invented terms), B (duration as label), C (ambiguous check affordance)*

3 participants stalled on at least one label, and in each case the confusion was about what the label meant and what the outcome would be.

A. P4 stopped at "choose an anchor," did not recognize the word as meaning "task," and suggested renaming it. P5 questioned "What's today's anchors section?" and later paused at "Start weekly briefing," not reading it as an action they could take. P2 questioned whether a feature was even part of the flow: "Focus session...? Is that part of this?"

B. "Start 5 min" label was the most consistent misread in the user study, across three participants. P5: "What does start in five minutes mean? It takes five minutes to do?" P1 said both possible readings without being able to choose between them: "Is the time like a reminder for you in 25 minutes you should start this task or is it this task will be 25 minutes long, and you're setting the timer?" and separately guessed "Maybe it's telling you how long the task is?" P4 also paused at the same button, unsure whether it started the task itself or only a timer.

C. Some button's outcomes were uncertain. P1 hovered over a task circle and asked "If I click this, would it be accomplished or?" P4 also hesitated at the same control, unsure what state a tap would commit her to.

The language/terms used that gives this Anchor app its identity is the same language that slows use for first-time users, and the problem is mostly at the moment of initiation, which is also the moment our target users already struggle with.

Insight: To make the app more usable, we should use terms the user is already familiar with, like simply using “Choose 3 tasks” rather than “Choose 3 Anchors.”

Theme 2: Lack of clear app-status feedback, and ability to undo or back out

Codes: *D (trapped in the timer), E (irreversible state), F (silent action, no end signal), I (missing time structure)*

This theme rests most heavily on P4, who is our closest match to the target user.

D. P4 finished a focus session early and found no way to end it, then no way to leave the timer screen at all. She also noted the timer overlay blocks the bottom of the screen, removing her navigation while she was already stuck.

E. She tried to reverse the “I started” state and stopped when nothing responded, and later wanted to edit a task after marking it started, with no path to do so.

F. She cleared her tasks and could not tell whether the action had taken effect. The same absence of signal appeared at the end of a session as well, where P1 asked “*Will it ring when it’s over?*” and said “*It might feel like an extra step because I use Google Calendar or personal alarms, so it’s nice to have the actual physical sound like vibration...for this one, you have to check your phone to see when time is up.*” P5 went looking for a sound or alarm setting that did not exist.

I. Beyond the session itself, time is largely invisible. P1 asked for it twice: “*When adding your task, adding a specific time so they’re like in order would be better*” and “*Alarm setting or something when you’re tasked, I think adding a time factor like 10 minutes pretty much to be your reminder part.*” P5 wanted the This Week strip to show both weekday and date: “*having both the date but also the day of the week could be useful, just like referencing.*” P4 asked for due dates on task rows and the ability to extend them.

Insight: For a user group whose central difficulty is starting, a system that makes a premature or mistaken start irreversible or silent would lower the chance of them trying at all.

Theme 3: The features users valued most were the ones they discovered last

Codes: *G (hidden closing step), H (depth only found on second look), J (visual design and Garden), K (reflection framing valued), L (reduces mental load, structure appreciated), M. (First-step suggestion was liked, but users want control over the breakdown, or show future steps)*

The evaluation found genuine enthusiasm for Anchor's core values, but found it is not easily accessible during the first run.

J. The Garden drew the most consistent unprompted praise, as it was not part of the initial 3 user tasks. P2 said: *"I like that there's a visual to like, I guess, visualize your progress and it gives a metaphor for like this and then maybe you'll get it to see more beautiful as you work through it."* P4 also said the Garden looks nice, and thought it was the unique feature in the app that made it prettier, and rated the app against her current stack saying *"Compared to other things I use, it's better, it's prettier. I just use a calendar and reminders app."*

L. P4 named the core value of the app when saying *"I just do what this app does in my head, so this would help reduce mental load."* P5 liked the organization once understood, and P3 recognized the structure as *"a homepage for future oriented stuff."*

K. P5 liked the reflection part the most saying *"I like the reflection section and also it includes health stuff like steps of the day which a lot of people are trying to keep up with. And also just reflection of what got in the way, it helps you focus on, okay, I identify the problem, but now I have to solve that going forward."*

G. Yet P4 never navigated to Reflection unprompted and would not have thought to look for it: *"The reflection part was not clear that it is a pipeline to close the day at the end of the day."* She recommended surfacing it on the Today page.

P3 described the same problem broadly saying *"It felt like off the bat, kinda todo notes app, not apparent until I dig more deep than that more like reflection and breaking things down."*

H. P5 on the Garden: *"The garden section, I didn't know what it was until I looked at it more. I think generally just getting used to how everything works together, it's organized, it just takes a bit of getting used to."* Similarly, P4 said *"It's a lot more intuitive trying it the second time,"* showing that there is a learning curve, even if short.

M. The first-step suggestion is the one differentiator 3 users encountered immediately, and it was received well. P3 said *"Part of me wants to write more like a description, but I do like the first step suggestion,"* and P2 and P4 wanted it to go further, with P2 saying *"I'm wondering if it would tell me the following tasks after the first step... because like thesis research is like a really broad thing,"* and P4 asking *"Would it show the next step when I am done?"* Both wanted more control over the breakdown rather than less of it, which suggests the feature is working and users want more of it.

It also shows that the app's approach works when it appears at the point of use rather than behind a tab you have to navigate.

Insight: Anchor's differentiating features are useful, but for first time users, the app can feel like another to-do list. Users have to spend effort learning it before reaching the reflection,

breakdown, and visual garden progress that make it worth using. Adding a guided walkthrough might be helpful for first time users. We can also clarify language and lessen text to make the signifying buttons stand out.

5) Next Steps & Future Iterations

1. Add a guided walkthrough that teaches the daily loop on first open

Finding: Every participant needed a second pass before the app made sense (Code H). P4 said “*It’s a lot more intuitive trying it the second time.*” P5 said “*generally just getting used to how everything works together, it’s organized, it just takes a bit of getting used to.*” P3 took roughly two minutes to discover he could set a date while adding a task, ending with “*It took me around 2 minutes to figure out this, but now I feel good about it.*” P4 never opened Reflection on her own, partly because nothing prompted her to (Code G).

Change: Add a short first-run walkthrough that runs the full loop once with sample content: morning briefing, pick three, start a session, then reflection. The app already succeeds on second use, so the goal is to deliver the second-run experience on the first run.

2. Rename product-specific labels to familiar action words

Finding: All five participants stalled on at least one label (Code A). P4 did not know what “choose an anchor” meant and suggested “choose a task.” P5 asked “*What’s the today’s anchors section?*” and did not read “Start weekly briefing” as an action.

Change: Rename “Anchor” to “Task” or “Today’s 3” in the interface, keeping “Anchor” as the app’s name rather than its vocabulary. Rewrite section headers as actions (“Plan my week” instead of “Start weekly briefing”). Retest whether new users can state what each button does before pressing it.

3. Make every action reversible and confirmed

Finding: Codes D, E, F. P4 finished a session early with no way to end it and no way to leave the timer screen, tried to undo “I started” and got no response, and cleared her tasks without being able to tell whether it worked. The timer overlay also blocked the bottom of the screen while she was stuck.

Change: Add a “Done” and an exit control to the timer, make “I started” tappable to undo and the task editable afterward, and add a confirmation message plus undo option when tasks are cleared. Keep navigation visible during a session.

4. Add notifications and optional alarms/vibration so the app reaches users when they are not in it

Finding: Three participants went looking for an end of session signal that did not exist (Code F). P1 asked “*Will it ring when it’s over?*” and explained “*It might feel like an extra step because I use Google Calendar or personal alarms, so it’s nice to have the actual physical sound like vibration...for this one, you have to check your phone to see when time is up.*” P5 searched for a sound setting and could not confirm one existed. P1 also asked for alerts ahead of tasks: “*Alarm setting or something when you’re tasked, I think adding a time factor like 10 minutes pretty much to be your reminder part.*” Separately, P4 never opened Reflection on her own, because nothing prompted her to. (Code G).

Change: This was initially a design choice to not add an alarm so as to not pull a user out of a focus zone. However an optional alarm setting would still be good for users that need it. Add sound and vibration when a focus session ends, with a screen-on option so the countdown stays visible. P2 user also mentioned a subtle “alarm” using the garden metaphor, so the user is not pulled out of their tasks. Add a configurable reminder before a task is due. Add morning and evening notifications that open the briefing and the reflection directly, which also solves the discovery problem for the closing step.

5. Show due dates on tasks, and let users edit deadlines and catch missed ones

Finding: Three participants wanted time attached to tasks (Code I). P1 asked twice: “*When adding your task, adding a specific time so they’re in order would be better.*” P5 wanted clearer date referencing: “*having both the date but also the day of the week could be useful, just like referencing.*” P3 wanted calendar context while entering tasks: “*When I’m editing this (tasks), part of me wants to see the calendar...cuz it’s easier to add.*”

P4 wanted due dates shown on task rows and the ability to extend them if they received an extension on an assignment. P4 also noticed that missed deadlines that you never added did not rollover.

Change: Show the due date/time on each task row, and let users edit or extend it in place, and also give them the ability to reorder tasks. Roll missed deadlines forward into the next day’s briefing rather than letting them disappear silently, flagged as overdue so the user decides whether to reschedule or drop them. Show weekdays and date together in “This Week” screen.